At the same time, Iltumish did his best to invade the still-Hindu lands that had not fallen to Ghurid rule. The kingdom of Orissa, on the eastern coast, suffered from fighting on its northern borders but managed to hold off the newcomers. A few Rajput kingdoms survived in central India, battered but still unconquered. Mewar, some 280 miles inland from the Indian Ocean, was chief among them; Iltumish mounted a major assault against the Hindu ruler of Mewar, Jaitra Singh, but although he was able to sack the city of Aghata, Jaitra Singh held out against him.

The repulse of the Muslim forces from Mewar was hailed, by the Hindus of India, as a religious victory. Iltumish, after all, was a Muslim ruler, remembered in his inscriptions as "protector of God's territories," builder of mosques and minarets. Halfway through his sultanate, the caliph in Baghdad —still holding on to the bare remnants of Abbasid power—recognized his rule by awarding him both a robe of honor and the ceremonial title *Sultan-i-azam*, "Great Sultan," legitimate and God-ordained ruler over his conquered lands; this gave Iltumish and his successors the right to use the title "Auxiliary of the Commander of the Faithful" on their coins. The Hindu deities, as an inscription celebrating Jaitra Singh's resistance exclaims, were "intoxicated with a drink of the blood" of the Muslim soldiers who had attacked them. Jaitra Singh's successful defense of his crown was also a defense of the Hindu world against the Muslim invaders.[8]

Yet at the same time, Iltumish was pragmatically aware that the Hindus in his realm had to be treated gently. He promised them the status of *dhimmi*: non-Muslim subjects of a Muslim king, allowed to hold property and to claim legal rights but exempt from Islamic requirements, like resident aliens in a modern nation-state. Like the Crusaders, Iltumish was savvy enough to separate political realities from religious aspirations.[9]

In 1236, the Sultan of Delhi—now in his twenty-sixth year of rule—was campaigning against rebels hiding in the Salt Range mountains, north of his capital, when he became too ill to sit on his horse. He was carried back to Delhi and died there in April.[10]

He had fathered at least four children, three sons and a daughter; his oldest son, who had been governing Bengal as his vice-regent, had died prematurely seven years earlier, and his two younger sons were (in his eyes) weak and incompetent. So, shocking his people to their core, he left the title of Sultan of Delhi to his daughter Raziyya, twenty-one years old; in the words of the historian Peter Jackson, with "all the attributes of a successful ruler except one . . . she was not a man."[11]

Raziyya had her supporters, but although they managed to engineer her